Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

3 John

3 John 1:1

- The elder: See study note on 2 John 1:1.
- The New Testament mentions several people named Gaius (see Acts 19:29; 20:4; Romans 16:23; 1 Corinthians 1:14). It was a popular name in the Greco-Roman world.

3 John 1:1–4

The apostle John begins his letter with a common greeting. It includes:

- identifying himself and the person he is writing to,
- using a friendly greeting, such as beloved,
- offering wishes for the person's well-being, and
- expressing thanks for their friendship.

3 John 1:3

- The traveling teachers (literally brothers) were probably John's messengers. They traveled between churches, teaching the good news about Jesus and encouraging Christians (see 1:5, 10).
- your devotion to the truth: Gaius remained faithful to the message about Jesus Christ that the apostles taught. The false teachers denied that Jesus truly came in the flesh or that his death was a real sacrifice (compare 1 John 4:1–3).

3 John 1:4

Like in 2 John (see 2 John 1:1–4), John emphasizes the importance of knowing and following the truth. This stands in contrast to Diotrephes and those who follow him (3 John 1:9).

3 John 1:5

Gaius welcomed the traveling teachers (literally the brothers) who went from church to church to support the apostles' teaching about Christ (1:7–8). By doing this, Gaius demonstrated that he had received the truth from the apostles and was faithful to God.

3 John 1:5–8

John encourages Gaius to keep supporting the traveling teachers that John sent out (1:3).

3 John 1:6

The church mentioned here was probably in Ephesus, where John was likely staying. Ephesus was an important port city in the province of Asia and was the fourth-largest city in the Roman Empire. It later became an important center for the Christian community (Acts 18:19–19:41; 1 Timothy 1:3; 1 Peter 1:1; Revelation 2:1–7).

3 John 1:7–8

- On behalf of the Name: John did not need to specify whose name this was because early Christians understood that the Name referred to Jesus Christ (see Acts 5:41).
- The traveling teachers had chosen to accept nothing offered to them from people who are not Christians. Instead, they relied on the churches for support. Christians who give support to trustworthy traveling teachers share in their work as those teachers spread the truth (see Matthew 10:41–42; Philippians 4:15–19).

3 John 1:9

- I have written to the church about this: This could refer to 1 John or to a letter that is now lost.
- Diotrephes was proud and thought himself important. He was motivated by selfish ambition (see 1 Timothy 3:6).
- will not accept our instruction: This disagreement was a major issue that John addressed in 1 John (see, for example, 1 John 2:19; 4:5–6). Diotrephes rejected the teachers sent by John and removed any church members who accepted them. He wanted to lead the local church without answering to any outside authority.

3 John 1:9–12

In these verses, John condemns Diotrephes and presents Demetrius as the model of a faithful Christian who lives according to the truth. John encourages Gaius to follow the example of Demetrius.

3 John 1:11

the one who does evil: John condemns Diotrephes for not living by the Christian rule of love (1 John 3:10–14). This was how Gaius could be sure that Diotrephes was not living according to the truth. This applies to all who refuse to accept the apostolic teaching about Jesus Christ and refuse to live in fellowship with others who do.

3 John 1:12

- Demetrius was the opposite of Diotrephes. Demetrius was a clear example of a person who knows the truth and lives according to it (1:3). His name appears at the end of the letter. This suggests

that he was the person who carried John's letter to Gaius (compare Colossians 4:7–9; 1 Peter 5:12).
- you know that our testimony is true: John wanted to protect his honor as a trustworthy elder for these churches. He did not want Diotrephes or other false teachers to challenge or replace his leadership.

3 John 1:13

with pen and ink (literally ink and reed): n ancient times, people often wrote with a pen made from a reed and with black carbon ink (see also 2 John 1:12).

3 John 1:13–15

As in 2 John, the end of 3 John shows John's desire to visit in person and make sure the instructions in this letter are followed.

3 John 1:14

The English expression face to face is similar in meaning to the Greek expression used here, which means "mouth to mouth" (literally) (see also 2 John 1:12). In Greek, the phrase "mouth to mouth" is an idiom that means close, direct, and personal communication. It pictures two people speaking to each other without anything in between.

3 John 1:14–15

- John closes his letter with his farewell and with greetings to others.
- Peace to you: This was a traditional Jewish greeting (Matthew 10:12; Luke 10:5–6). It became more meaningful for Christians because Jesus used it after his resurrection (John 20:19–21, 26).
- Greet each of our friends there by name: John expected Gaius to greet the friends. This meant those who accept the good news about Jesus taught by the apostles and live according to the truth (compare 3 John 1:3–4).